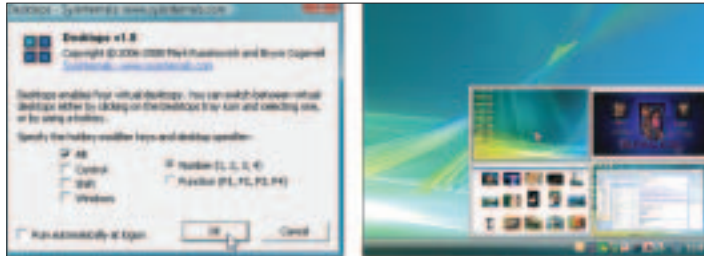


Launch Desktops and you'll discover a simple and elegant solution: three new desktops. If you've launched too many tools on your main desktop, say, launch the Desktops program as well, and when you see its system tray icon (four blue squares) press Alt+2. A second blank desktop will open, with just your desktop wallpaper, task bar and Start menu. You can then launch new programs here, just as normal. Press Alt+3 and Alt+4 to open additional desktops



as required, or Alt+1 if you need to switch back to your original desktop. Alternatively, just click the Desktops system tray icon to see preview windows of your four desktops, select the one you need, and Desktops will switch to it immediately. It's a clever tool that really can boost your PC productivity, but keep in mind there's no way to delete a desktop object and so you can't close the program. If you want to exit Desktops, then log off or reboot.

System requirements: Windows Vista, 1MB disk space

Contact: www.tinyurl.com/5fywm3

Need to know: Desktops is a Microsoft Sysinternals program. Check www.tinyurl.com/5fywm3 regularly for more information and the latest updates.

FreeCommander 2008.06b

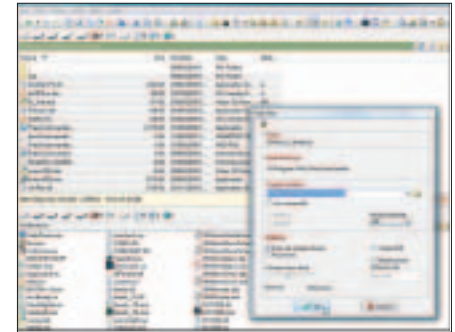
This easy-to-use Explorer replacement saves time and avoids file management hassles

If you're not happy with the Windows Vista Explorer then you could try tweaking it, choosing new window layouts and other options to see if they'll improve matters. But you'll probably get much better results by using another file manager altogether,

such as FreeCommander.

The dual-pane layout makes it much easier to copy files, for instance. Just open one folder in the left-hand pane, another in the right, then drag and drop your files across. A tabbed interface means it's extremely quick to switch between drives. If you want to explore the DVD in drive D, perhaps, there's no scrolling through Computer — you just click the D icon on the toolbar.

The program comes with some very useful file selection options. If you want to select all the JPEG images in a folder using Explorer, say, then you usually have to hold down Ctrl and click each one in turn. With FreeCommander all you do is choose one, click Edit > Select Files with the same extension, and the program will select all the others for you. You also get a powerful file viewer, built-in archive handling (ZIP, RAR and CAB formats), an easy way to rename multiple files in a single step, and much more. Give it a try — you'll be surprised just how much time you can save.



System requirements: Windows 2000/XP/Vista, 5MB hard disk space

Contact: www.freecommander.com

Need to know: The authors also provide a free file viewer, editor, and other tools to use with FreeCommander. Find out more at www.freecommander.com/fc_utilities_en.htm.

O&O DiskImage 3 Express Edition

Create an exact backup copy of your hard disk without worrying about tricky settings

The Windows Vista Business, Enterprise and Ultimate editions come with a Complete PC Backup and Restore tool that makes it easy to back up your entire hard disk. Windows Vista Home Basic and Home Premium users don't get this, unfortunately, but